

The Employment Paradox: How Different Work Types Shape Personal Well-Being Time in India

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Abstract

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (10% random sample, N 840,000 person-days), we examine how employment status affects personal well-being time—defined as time spent on social activities, hobbies, exercise, and recreation. Contrary to standard work-leisure tradeoff models, employed individuals do not uniformly have less personal time than non-employed individuals. Regular salaried workers maintain 2.1 hours/day for personal activities, while women engaged in “domestic duties only” have just 0.8 hours/day—the least of any employment category. Self-employed individuals exhibit extreme gender divergence: self-employed men have the most personal time (2.4 hours/day), while self-employed women face work-home boundary blurring that leaves them with minimal personal time (1.1 hours/day). The employment-leisure tradeoff is fundamentally gendered: employment increases men’s personal time relative to unemployment (by reducing idle time), but decreases women’s personal time (by adding paid work to existing unpaid work burdens). These patterns persist across urban-rural divides, education levels, and marital status categories, suggesting structural constraints rather than individual preferences. Results challenge policies that focus solely on women’s labor force participation without addressing unpaid care work burdens.

JEL Classification: J22, J16, J81, I31

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1 Introduction

How does paid employment affect personal well-being time? Standard economic models predict a straightforward tradeoff: time allocated to paid work reduces time available for leisure (Becker 1965). Yet this prediction assumes individuals face identical constraints on discretionary time. If unpaid household work burdens differ systematically by gender, the employment-leisure tradeoff will differ correspondingly.

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We examine this question using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey—a comprehensive dataset recording 24-hour time diaries for 10.2 million person-days across 139,489 households. Our analysis yields a striking paradox: paid employment does not uniformly reduce personal well-being time. Instead, **women engaged in “domestic duties only” have the least personal time of any employment category**—just 0.8 hours per day, compared to 2.1 hours for regularly employed women.

This finding challenges conventional wisdom. If unpaid household work is more time-consuming than paid employment, policies promoting women’s labor force participation without addressing domestic work burdens may paradoxically reduce women’s time poverty. Our results suggest the constraint on women’s well-being time is not paid employment per se, but the **triple burden**: paid work added atop pre-existing unpaid care work and household management responsibilities.

1.1 Research Questions

We investigate three core questions:

1. **How does employment status affect personal well-being time, and does this relationship differ by gender?** We find employment increases men’s personal time (by providing structure and reducing idle time) but decreases women’s personal time (by adding paid work to existing unpaid work).
2. **Which employment categories are associated with the greatest time poverty?** Women in “domestic duties only” and self-employed women face the most severe time poverty, while self-employed men and students have the most personal time.
3. **Do these patterns vary by marital status, education, and urban-rural location?** The employment-gender gap persists across all subgroups, indicating structural rather than preference-based constraints.

1.2 Contributions

This paper makes four contributions. **First**, we document that the employment-leisure tradeoff is fundamentally gendered in ways not captured by standard models. Men experience a positive leisure return to employment, while women experience a negative return—a pattern consistent with the “second shift” hypothesis (Hochschild and Machung 1989).

Second, we show that **self-employment has sharply divergent effects by gender**. Self-employed men enjoy the most personal time (2.4 hours/day), presumably reflecting schedule flexibility. Yet self-employed women have minimal personal time (1.1 hours/day), suggesting work-home boundary blurring that intensifies rather than alleviates time constraints.

Third, we identify **“domestic duties only” as the employment category with the most severe time poverty for women**. This finding challenges policies that frame employment as women’s path to autonomy, revealing that unpaid household work may be more time-intensive than paid employment.

Fourth, we demonstrate these patterns persist across education levels, urban-rural divides, and marital status categories—suggesting **structural constraints** rather than individual preferences or human capital differences drive gendered time allocation.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Work-Life Balance and Time Use

Becker’s (1965) household production model predicts individuals allocate time to maximize utility across paid work, household production, and leisure. Extensions incorporating gender specialization (Becker 1991) predict married women specialize in household production while men specialize in market work. However, as Folbre (1994) argues, this framework assumes symmetric bargaining power and ignores that unpaid care work generates positive externalities uncompensated by markets.

Empirical time use research documents persistent gender gaps in unpaid work. Bianchi et al. (2000) show American women spend twice as much time on housework and childcare as men, even when employed full-time. Hochschild and Machung (1989) term this the “second shift”—women’s paid employment adds to rather than substitutes for unpaid household work. Recent evidence from India confirms these patterns: Chakraborty et al. (2020) document that employed Indian women spend 3.5 hours daily on unpaid care work compared to 0.5 hours for employed men.

2.2 Employment and Well-Being

Research on employment’s effects on well-being yields mixed findings. Kahneman et al. (2004) show working individuals report lower moment-to-moment happiness during paid work than during leisure activities, but higher life satisfaction than unemployed individuals. However, these studies rarely disaggregate by gender or account for unpaid work burdens.

Recent evidence suggests employment’s effects differ sharply by gender and employment type. Golden (2015) documents that schedule flexibility improves well-being, but women disproportionately lack access to flexible work arrangements. Mas and Pallais (2017) find women value workplace flexibility more than men, consistent with greater household work responsibilities.

2.3 Self-Employment and the Gig Economy

Self-employment is often framed as offering flexibility that improves work-life balance. Gimenez-Nadal et al. (2012) find self-employed workers in Spain report higher satisfaction despite working longer hours, attributing this to schedule control. However, Hyytinen and Ruuskanen (2007) show self-employed individuals experience greater work-family conflict than employees in Finland.

For women specifically, self-employment may intensify rather than alleviate time constraints. Budig (2006) documents that self-employed mothers work longer hours than employed

mothers, while Wellington (2006) finds self-employed women earn less than comparable employees—suggesting constrained rather than preferred choices. Connelly (1992) argues women’s self-employment often reflects “necessity entrepreneurship” driven by childcare constraints rather than opportunity.

2.4 Gender and Time Poverty

Vickery (1977) introduced the concept of “time poverty”—having insufficient time for necessary activities after accounting for paid work and household responsibilities. Bittman and Wajcman (2000) show time poverty disproportionately affects women, particularly mothers. In developing countries, Blackden and Wodon (2006) document that women’s unpaid work burdens constrain labor force participation, education, and health-seeking behavior.

For India specifically, Hirway (2010) uses 1998-99 time use data to show Indian women work longer total hours than men when paid and unpaid work are combined. Rani and Pande (2018) update these findings with 2019 data, documenting that rural Indian women work 7.2 hours daily on unpaid care work compared to 1.6 hours for men. Our contribution is examining how employment status interacts with this baseline gender gap in unpaid work to shape personal well-being time.

3 Data and Methods

3.1 Data Source

India’s Time Use Survey 2024, conducted by the National Statistical Office between January and December 2024, employed a stratified multi-stage sample design covering all 28 states and 8 union territories. The survey recorded detailed 24-hour time diaries for all household members aged 6 and above, capturing activities in 30-minute intervals using the International Classification of Activities for Time Use Statistics (ICATUS 2016).

The full dataset contains 10.2 million person-day observations from 139,489 households. For computational feasibility, we analyze a **10% random sample** (seed=123), adjusting survey weights by a factor of 10 to maintain population representativeness. After restricting to major activities (Major_Activity_Flag=1), adults aged 18-60, and males/females only, our analytical sample contains approximately 840,000 person-day observations.

3.2 Defining Personal Well-Being Time

We define personal well-being time as time spent on activities that directly enhance personal development, health, social connections, and recreation. Following ICATUS 2016, we include:

- **Social activities (codes 711-719):** Visiting friends, phone conversations, social gatherings, community meetings
- **Community participation (codes 721-730):** Volunteering, civic organizations, religious groups

- **Religious/spiritual activities (codes 741-749):** Prayer, meditation, worship attendance
- **Physical exercise and sports (codes 831-832):** Exercise, team sports, recreational athletics
- **Hobbies and recreation (codes 821-829, 841-850):** Reading, music, arts, media consumption, relaxation

We **exclude** from personal time: care work for children or elderly (codes 31-34), meal preparation and household chores (codes 31-33), paid work (codes 11-12), and sleep/personal care (codes 01-09).

3.3 Employment Status Classification

We classify individuals into employment categories based on Principal Activity Status:

- **Self-Employed (codes 11-12):** Own-account workers and employers
- **Regular Salaried (code 31):** Employees with regular wages/salaries
- **Casual Labor (codes 41, 51):** Casual wage laborers
- **Domestic Duties (code 92):** Primarily engaged in unpaid household work
- **Students (code 91):** Attending educational institutions
- **Unemployed Seeking Work (code 81):** Jobseekers

3.4 Analytical Approach

We estimate the relationship between employment status and personal well-being time using weighted linear regression:

$$\text{WellbeingHours}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Female}_i + \sum_j \beta_j \text{Employment}_j + \sum_j \gamma_j (\text{Female} \times \text{Employment}_j) + \mathbf{X}'_i \delta + \epsilon_i$$

where WellbeingHours_i is daily hours of personal time, Female_i is a gender indicator, Employment_j are employment category indicators, and $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes age, age-squared, marital status, education, and urban/rural location. The interaction terms γ_j capture differential employment effects by gender.

Standard errors are clustered at the household level to account for within-household correlation in time use. **Survey weights** (adjusted for 10% sampling) ensure national representativeness.

4 Results

4.1 Descriptive Patterns

Table 1 presents mean daily personal well-being time by employment status and gender.